

TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

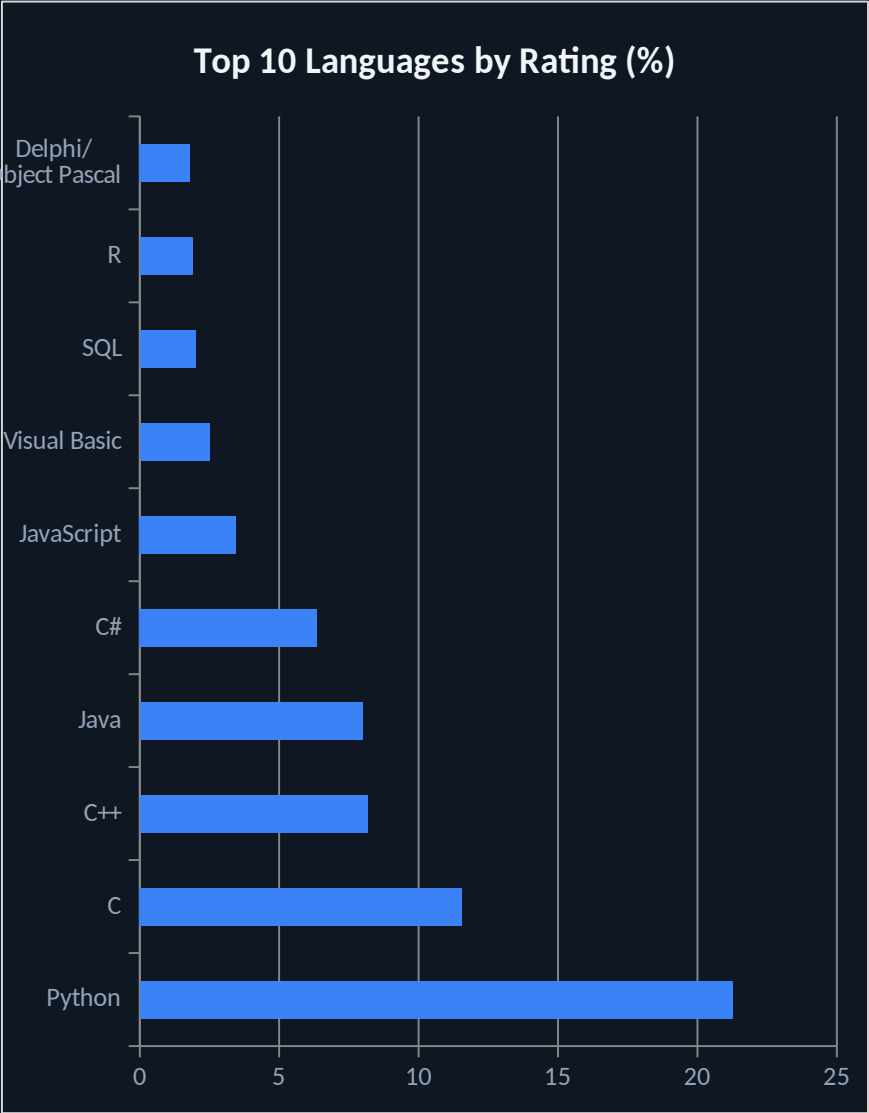
Data-forward analysis of programming language popularity trends for technology decision-makers

Source: TIOBE Software • Captured: April 2026 • Audience:
Engineering Leads & Tech Strategists
Ratings derived from search-engine hit counts across Google, Bing,
Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ other sites

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Full top-20 ranking with March 2026 position, prior-year position, rating, and year-over-year change

Rank	Prev Rank	Language	Rating	YoY Change
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%



Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 — The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

Visual contrast of the most dramatic rank movers: gainers vs. losers

▲ GAINERS

Perl

Year-over-year rating change: +1.05%

#24 → #11

R

Year-over-year rating change: +0.94%

#16 → #9

Swift

Year-over-year rating change: +0.44%

#26 → #20

▼ LOSERS

Go

Year-over-year rating change: -1.49%

#7 → #16

C++

Year-over-year rating change: -2.90%

#2 → #3

Java

Year-over-year rating change: -2.37%

#3 → #4

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Long-term ranking snapshots across four decades (1986–2026)

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	-	-
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	-	-
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	-	-	-
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	-	-
Go	10	11	60	16	-	-	-	-	-
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

Python's Meteoric Rise

Unranked before 1991 → #1 by 2026, peaking above 25%

C's Unmatched Resilience

Only language in the top 2 across all 9 measurement points since 1986

Java's Long Decline

Dominated 2005–2018 at 25%+; now under 8% and falling

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times — More Than Any Other Language

TIOBE Programming Language of the Year winners (2016–2025). Awarded to the language with the largest annual rating gain.

Year	Winner
2025	C#
2024	Python
2023	C#
2022	C++
2021	Python
2020	Python
2019	C
2018	Python
2016	Go

Python: 6 Wins

2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024
Most decorated language in TIOBE history

C#: Back-to-Back Power

Won in 2023 and 2025
Reflects sustained .NET ecosystem growth

Go: Rise Then Fall

Won in 2016 but dropped from 7th to 16th in 2026
Possible displacement by Rust in systems programming

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Key findings and actionable implications for engineering leads and technology strategists

Python Dominance vs. Decline

At 21.25%, Python leads by 2× over C. Yet its -2.59pp YoY drop is the largest among the top 5. Plan for a gradual diversification of your Python-heavy stack.

Go's Sharp Fall

Go dropped from 7th to 16th (-1.49pp). If you're betting on Go for systems work, evaluate Rust (14th, +0.09%) as a hedge.

C's Resurgence

C climbed from 4th to 2nd (+2.02pp). For performance-critical systems and embedded teams, C expertise is becoming more strategic, not less.

Concentration Risk

Python + C + C++ + Java = 48.97% of the index. Over-reliance on these four creates talent and tooling monoculture risk.

Legacy Language Revival

Perl (+13 ranks), R (+7), and Fortran (top 15) prove legacy ecosystems retain value. Don't abandon mature codebases without cost-benefit analysis.

Swift vs. Kotlin Signal

Swift re-entered the top 20; Kotlin fell to 22nd. Apple-platform investments are trending up; reassess cross-platform vs. native mobile strategies.